INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE · UNIT 3 ASSIGNMENT

# Unit 3 Assignment — Easy Notes

All 12 questions answered in very simple English, with real-life examples, small diagrams and a short exam answer for each one.

Part A · Q1–Q5 · Organizing information

Part B · Q6–Q8 · Browser, context, flexibility

Part C · Q9–Q12 · Navigation & usability

Based on the Unit 3 & 4 study material (Information Architecture for the World Wide Web) plus simple general knowledge where the questions go beyond it

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# How to read these notes

⭐ **Short answer for exam — Every answer has the same 4 parts**

1. **In simple words** — the idea in one or two easy lines (blue box).
2. **Explanation** — points, tables and diagrams, using everyday examples (library, supermarket, mall, map).
3. **Real-life example** — so it sticks in your head.
4. **Short answer for exam** — a ready-to-write summary (yellow box). If you have little time, learn only this.

⚠️ **Careful — Honest note**

Questions 1, 5 and 12 (basic idea of organizing, metadata/tags, accessibility) are wider than the textbook chapters. For those I used the textbook ideas (classification, controlled vocabulary, scope notes) and added short, standard general knowledge. Everything else follows the textbook.

## The big picture in 30 seconds

Imagine a huge shop. **Organizing** = deciding which things go on which shelf. **Labeling** = writing signs for the shelves. **Navigation** = the maps, aisle boards and arrows that help you walk to the right shelf. A website is the same, just with information instead of goods.

| Questions | Topic | Shop comparison |
|---|---|---|
| Q1–Q5 | Organizing information | Which item goes on which shelf, and how shelves are arranged |
| Q6–Q8 | Browser, context, flexibility | Knowing where you are in the shop and being able to move freely |
| Q9–Q11 | Navigation systems | Aisle boards, shop map, help desk |
| Q12 | Usability & accessibility | A shop that is easy for EVERY customer to use |

PART A · QUESTIONS 1–5

# Organizing Information

What is organizing | Challenges | Websites & intranets | Cohesive system | WWW, metadata & categories

## Q1. Concept of organizing information — why is it essential for retrieval?

**In simple words**

**Organizing information** means putting information into **groups (categories)** and giving them **names (labels)** so that people can **find** and **understand** it easily. Another word for this is **classification**.

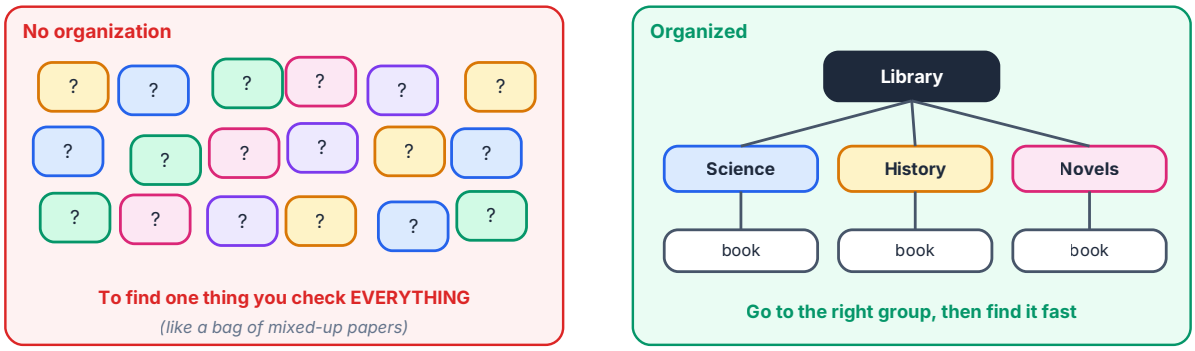



**Fig. 1** — Same items — messy pile vs organized shelves

### Why do we need it?

- On the Web **everyone can publish**. Millions of pages are created every day. Without order, it is like a library where books are thrown on the floor.
- In the past, **librarians** did this job. Now every website owner must label, organize and catalog their own content.
- People come to a website with a need: "I want my result", "I want to buy shoes". If they cannot find it quickly, they **leave**.




**Fig. 2** — Steps of organizing information

### Why it is essential for retrieval (finding) on digital platforms

| Benefit | Explained simply |
|---|---|
| **Saves time** | You check one group, not millions of items. |
| **Better results** | Related items sit together, so users see what is relevant. |
| **Reduces confusion** | Clear names tell users what is inside each group. |
| **Supports browsing** | Even if you don't know the exact word, you can look through categories and discover things. |
| **Easy to maintain** | New content has an obvious place; old content is easy to update. |
| **Builds trust** | A tidy site looks professional; users feel in control. |

🌍 **Real-life example — Supermarket**

Milk is in the dairy aisle, rice in the grocery aisle. You never search the whole store for milk. A website's categories (Men, Women, Kids) do the same job.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

**Organizing information** = grouping content into logical categories and labeling them so users can find it. It is essential because the Web has huge, mixed content and anyone can publish; good organization saves time, gives relevant results, supports both searching and browsing, reduces confusion and makes content easy to manage.

## Q2. Challenges of organizing information — and how to solve them

📘 **In simple words**

Organizing is hard because **language is tricky, content is mixed, people think differently, and organizations have politics**. Remember: **A-H-P-P**.




**Fig. 3** — Four challenges of organizing information

### 1. Ambiguity (words have many meanings)

- Classification is built on **words**, and one word can mean many things. **"Pitch"** can mean a throw, a sales talk, a sound level, or the sticky black tar on ships.
- Even deciding the group is hard. Is a **tomato** a fruit, a vegetable or a berry?
- Abstract topics are worst: "alternative healing" could go under health, religion or philosophy.

**How to handle:** use clear labels, add short **scope notes** (one-line descriptions), and allow the same item in **two categories** (cross-listing) when needed.

### 2. Heterogeneity (mixed content)

- **Homogeneous** = all items alike (a box of identical biscuits, or a library catalogue that contains only books). **Heterogeneous** = unlike items mixed together.
- Websites are mixed in two ways: **different levels** (a whole database next to a single page) and **different formats** (text, images, video, audio, software).
- One strict scheme cannot fit all of them.

**How to handle:** split the site into smaller **homogeneous parts** and organize each part with the method that suits it.

### 3. Differences in perspectives (people think differently)

- The creator's logic may not match the user's logic. Folders named **/office/clients/red** and **/blue** make sense only to the person who made them.
- Companies arrange the site like their **internal departments** (Marketing, Sales, HR), but customers don't know those departments.

**How to handle: put yourself in the user's shoes**; study the audience; offer more than one way to reach the same thing.

### 4. Internal politics

- Every department wants its link on the home page. Names and positions affect how people see the company.
- Example: should the library link be called "The Library", "Information Services" or "Knowledge Management"?

**How to handle:** the information architect must be **sensitive**, keep reminding everyone to **design for the user**, and sometimes **compromise**.

🧠 **Remember this — A-H-P-P**

**A**mbiguity · **H**eterogeneity · **P**erspectives · **P**olitics

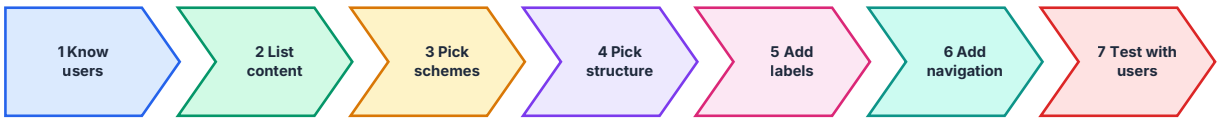
⭐ **Short answer for exam**

Four challenges: **ambiguity** (words have many meanings), **heterogeneity** (mixed formats and levels), **different perspectives** (creator and users think differently) and **internal politics**. Solutions: clear labels with scope notes, split content into homogeneous parts, understand the users, provide multiple access paths, and be diplomatic.

## Q3. Organizing websites and intranets — and how IA influences user experience

📘 **In simple words**

An **organization system** = **organization schemes** + **organization structures**.
**Scheme** = *how we group* the items (by alphabet, by date, by topic...).
**Structure** = *how groups are connected* (tree, database, links).




**Keep going back and improving — the design is never done in one go.**

*Testing shows where real users get lost.*

**Fig. 4** — Process of organizing a website or intranet

## Step 1 — Choose organization schemes (how to group)

**Exact schemes** have clear, no-argument groups. They suit users who **know exactly what they want** (known-item search).

| Scheme | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **Alphabetical** | A to Z order | Dictionary, phone book, staff directory |
| **Chronological** | By date/time | News archive, diary, TV guide |
| **Geographical** | By place | Weather by city, travel site with a map |

**Ambiguous schemes** have groups that are open to opinion. They are harder to build but very useful when users **don't know the exact word** and want to browse.

| Scheme | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **Topical** | By subject | Yellow pages, newspaper sections |
| **Task-oriented** | By what the user wants to DO | Menus like Edit / Insert / Format; "Select a car → find a dealer → choose finance" |
| **Audience-specific** | By type of user | "Students \| Teachers \| Parents" sections |
| **Metaphor-driven** | Compare with something familiar | Desktop, folders, trash can |

| | Exact schemes | Ambiguous schemes |
|---|---|---|
| Sections | well defined, mutually exclusive | categories defy exact definition |
| Search type | known-item (you know the name) | browsing, associative learning |
| Design / upkeep | easy — little intellectual work | hard — needs classification + indexing |
| Examples | phone-book white pages, author/title | yellow pages, Dewey, subject catalog |
| Weakness | must know exact name | subjective, language is ambiguous |

**Fig. 5** — Exact vs ambiguous schemes

**⚠️ Careful — Hybrid schemes confuse people**

A **hybrid** mixes several schemes in one list (some topics + some tasks + some audiences). Users cannot guess the logic. **Fix:** keep each scheme pure and show them in separate blocks.

## Step 2 — Choose organization structures (how groups connect)

| Structure | Idea | Good | Weak |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Hierarchy** (tree, top-down) | Parent → child groups, like a family tree | Simple, familiar; users see where they are | Too many levels or too many choices |
| **Database** (bottom-up) | Records with fields; search by field | Easy to manage and reuse content | Rigid; poor for mixed content |
| **Hypertext** (links) | Pieces joined by links, any direction | Very flexible | Users get lost |

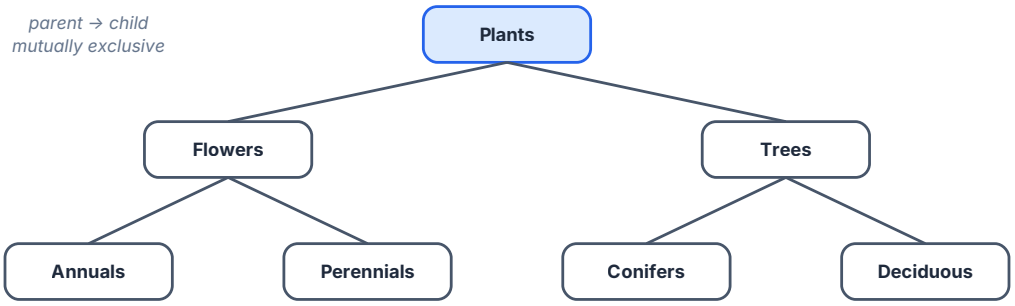



**Fig. 6** — Hierarchy — the base of most websites

## Hierarchy design rules (easy version)

- **Breadth** = how many choices on one level. **Depth** = how many levels. Don't go too wide (about **7 ± 2** choices is ideal; more than ~10 overwhelms users) and don't go too deep (users give up after **4–5 levels**).
- A growing site should be **broad and shallow** — new items can be added without redesign.
- Categories should not overlap, but a confusing item (tomato) may be listed in **two places**. Do this rarely.

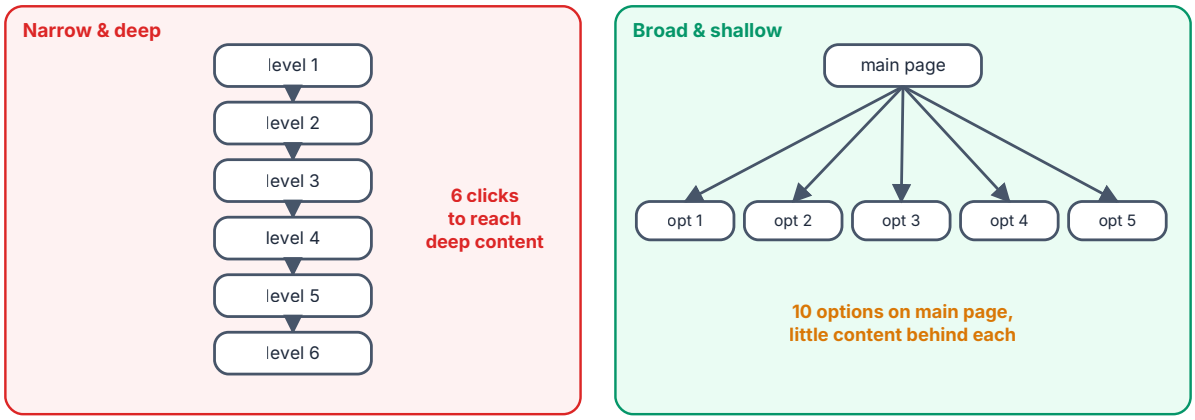



**Fig. 7** — Breadth vs depth

## Intranet vs website

An **intranet** is the company's private website for employees. Same rules apply, but **task-oriented** grouping works very well because employees do repeated tasks (apply for leave, submit expenses).

## How IA influences user experience (UX)

- **Findability:** good IA = users find things in few clicks.
- **Less frustration:** clear groups and labels prevent the "where am I?" feeling.

- **Confidence:** a familiar structure builds a mental map in the user's mind.
- **Business benefit:** happy users stay longer, buy more, call support less.

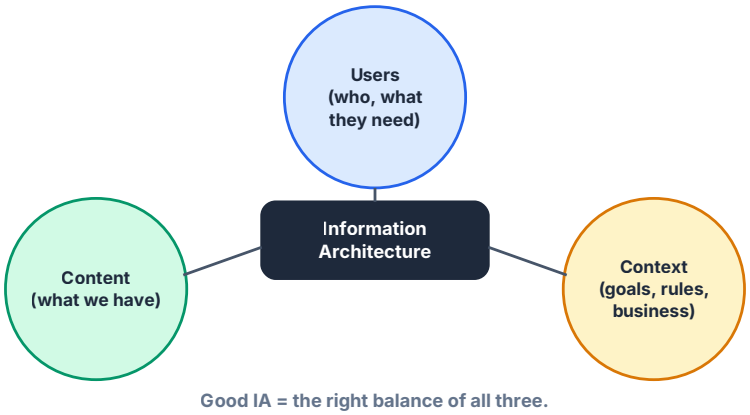



**Fig. 8** — IA balances users, content and context

🌍 **Real-life example — Mall**

Floor directory: Ground = Food, First = Clothes. That is hierarchy + topical scheme. A good mall plan means you reach the shoe shop without wandering.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

Organizing a site = choosing **schemes** (exact: alphabetical, chronological, geographical; ambiguous: topical, task, audience, metaphor; avoid hybrids) and **structures** (hierarchy, database, hypertext), usually combined. IA improves user experience by making content easy to find and understand, reducing confusion and building a clear mental model.

## Q4. Cohesive organization system — characteristics and importance

📘 **In simple words**

A **cohesive organization system** is a website organization where the schemes and structures **work together smoothly**, like a good recipe in which all ingredients blend. Good ingredients alone are not enough; they must mix well.

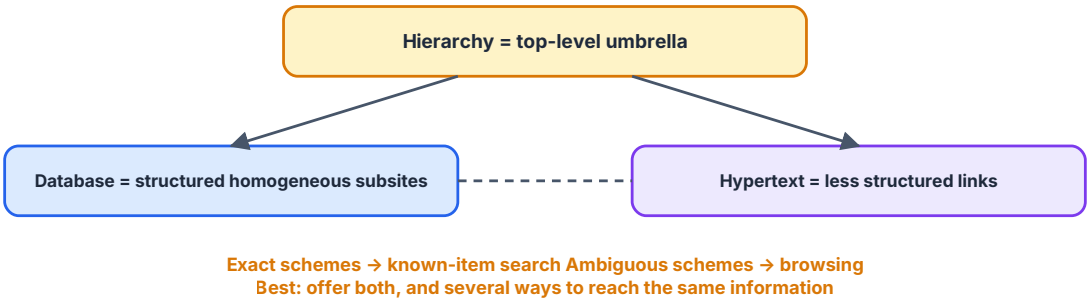



**Fig. 9** — Hierarchy + database + hypertext working together

### Characteristics

| Characteristic | Meaning |
|---|---|
| **Uses exact and ambiguous schemes together** | Exact → for users who know the name. Ambiguous → for users who want to browse. Offer both whenever possible. |
| **Combines all three structures** | **Hierarchy** = the main umbrella; **database** = structured, similar content (staff list, product catalogue); **hypertext** = loose relationships between items. |
| **Handles the 4 challenges** | Ambiguity, mixed content, different perspectives and politics are all considered. Gives **multiple ways** to reach the same information. |
| **Divided into small domains** | Large sites are split into narrow parts (homogeneous content), and one question is solved at a time. |
| **Keeps the big picture** | Parts must still fit together as one site. |
| **Pure schemes** | Different schemes are shown separately; no confusing hybrid lists. |

### Importance

- Users learn **one logic** for the entire site, so they never feel lost.
- Content is found by **different types of users** (those who know the name and those who browse).
- The site is **easier to grow and maintain**.
- Gives a **professional, consistent** impression of the organization.

🌍 **Real-life example — Hospital website**

Hierarchy: Departments → Doctors. Database: doctor directory searchable by name or speciality. Hypertext: "Related services" links. All three together = cohesive.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

A cohesive organization system blends exact and ambiguous schemes and the hierarchy, database and hypertext structures so they support each other. Its characteristics: multiple access paths, small homogeneous domains, pure schemes and attention to the four challenges. It matters because users get one clear logic, find information easily and the site is easy to maintain.

## Q5. Methods of organizing information on the WWW — role of metadata and categorization

📘 **In simple words**

On the Web, information is organized with **schemes** (how to group), **structures** (how to connect) and **descriptive data** such as metadata. **Metadata** = "data about data" (title, author, date, subject, keywords).

## Main methods

| Method | How it helps |
|---|---|
| **Hierarchical categories** | Directory-style tree (Home → Science → Physics). Good for browsing. |
| **Alphabetical / chronological / geographical lists** | Exact, fast for known items. |
| **Topical and other ambiguous schemes** | Subject groups, tasks, audiences. |
| **Database-driven pages** | Records and fields; users search any field; pages are generated automatically. |
| **Hypertext links** | The "web" itself — jump from one idea to related ones. |
| **Search + indexes** | Keyword search and A–Z indexes for quick access. |

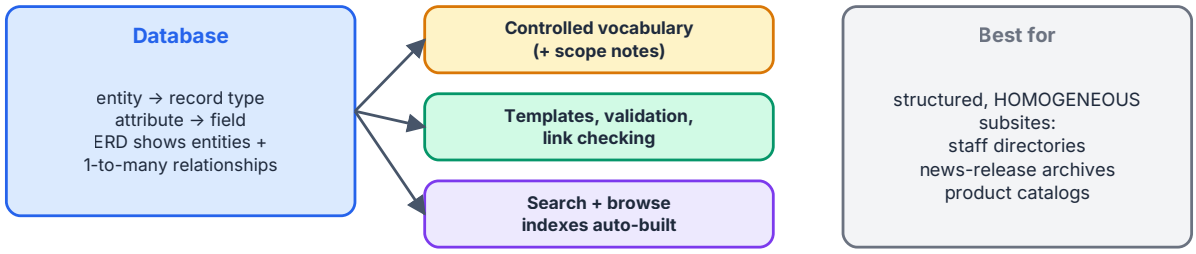



**Fig. 10** — Database model: one record, many pages and formats

## Role of metadata

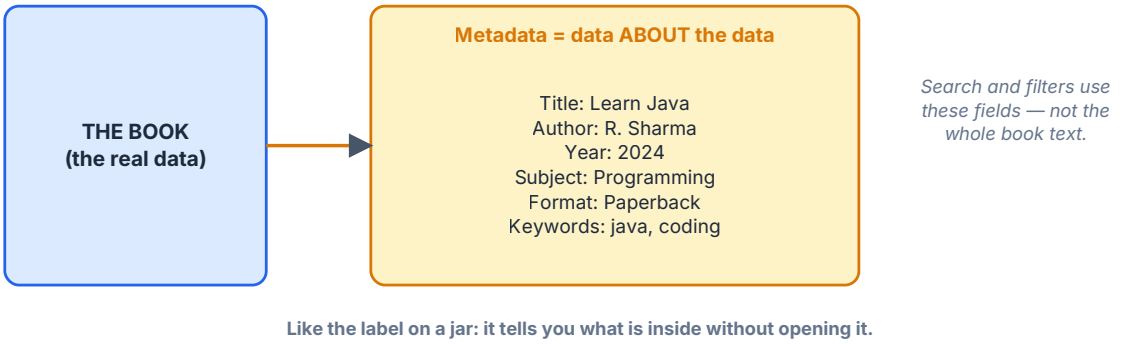



**Fig. 11** — Metadata — the label on the jar

- In the database model every record has **fields** (name, address, subject...). Each field is another way to **search or browse**.
- Fields such as "keywords" use a **controlled vocabulary** — an approved list of terms (for example always *biodiversity*, never *biological diversity*) so searching is consistent. **Scope notes** explain each term.
- Metadata lets the same content be **reused** in many forms (website, printed brochure) and lets computers automatically build **browse lists and indexes**.
- Search engines also use metadata (page title, description, keywords) to understand and list a page.

## Role of categorization

- It **groups similar items**, so users can narrow results step by step (Electronics → Phones → Under 20k).
- It lets users who don't know the right word **browse** and discover related information.
- Works best when every item is placed **accurately and consistently** (careful indexing).

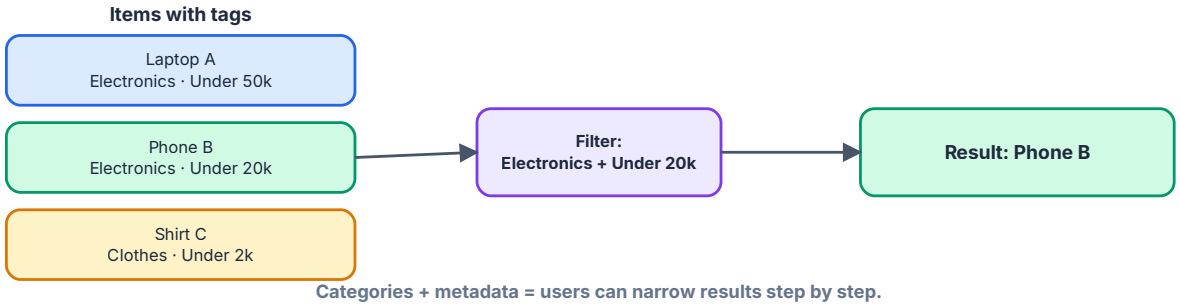



**Fig. 12** — Category + tag filter narrowing results

**⚠️ Careful — Controlled vocabulary needs effort**

Creating and maintaining one is not simple. A practical choice: a short controlled list of broad categories plus a free "keyword" field — structure and flexibility together.

**⭐ Short answer for exam**

The Web is organized using schemes (exact and ambiguous), structures (hierarchy, database, hypertext) and indexes/search. **Metadata** describes each item (title, author, subject, keywords) and, with a **controlled vocabulary**, makes searching and browsing consistent and allows reuse. **Categorization** groups similar items so users can browse and narrow down results.

PART B · QUESTIONS 6–8

# Browser, Context & Flexibility

Browser features | Building context | Flexibility

## Q6. Role of browser navigation features

**In simple words**

The **browser** (Chrome, Edge...) already gives users free tools to move around the Web. A good designer **uses** these tools and does not break them. A web page does not exist without a browser.




Fig. 13 — Browser navigation tools

| Feature | What it does | Everyday example |
|---|---|---|
| **Open URL** | Go straight to any page | Typing a known address |
| **Back / Forward** | Retrace your steps in both directions | Going back to the product list |
| **History** | List of pages you visited in the session; jump to any | "Where was that article?" |
| **Bookmark** | Save a page location for later | Saving your timetable page |
| **Link colours** | Unvisited and visited links look different, so you see where you've been ("bread crumbs") | Purple = already clicked |
| **Prospective view** | Pointing at a link shows its destination at the bottom of the window | Spot an outside website before clicking |

### How they help organize and access information

- They let users **return, repeat and save** — so people explore without fear of getting lost.
- They give **context**: visited colours show your path.
- They save designers effort — these tools need not be rebuilt on every page.

⚠️ **Careful — Do not corrupt the browser's features**

**Link colours:** do not change them just for looks (e.g. to match a logo); users must relearn your site. Change only with great care and keep a clear visited/unvisited difference.
**Server-side image maps:** these disable the prospective view (you see coordinates instead of the URL). Prefer client-side maps or simple tables for graphic navigation bars.
**Frames** often break bookmarks, back button and history.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

Browser features — **open URL, back/forward, history, bookmarks, link colours and prospective view** — let users move, return, save and see where they have been. Designers should leverage them and avoid breaking them (e.g. changing link colours, server-side image maps, frames).

## Q7. Building context — meaning and examples

📘 **In simple words**

**Building context** means always letting users know **where they are, which site they are on, and how that place fits in the whole site** — like the red "You Are Here" dot on a mall map.

### Why is it needed?

- The Web has **no natural landmarks** like a road or building.
- Users can jump into the **middle** of a site from a search result, a link or a printed page. They skip the front door and have no idea where they have landed.




Fig. 14 — A page that builds context

### How to build context

| Rule | Example |
|---|---|
| **Show the organization name and a consistent look on every page** | Logo + "ABC Shoes Ltd." in the header, even on a deep product page |
| **Show the hierarchy and current location clearly** | Path: Main Page → Government & Law → Intellectual Property |
| **Highlight the current page in the menu** | The "Men" menu item looks different when you are in Men |
| **Be consistent** | The same menu in the same place on all pages |

### How context improves understanding and usability

- Users build a **mental model** of the site — they understand what else is nearby.
- They **don't feel lost**, so less frustration and fewer abandoned visits.
- They can decide the **next step** quickly (go up a level, switch to a sibling page).

**🌍 Real-life example — Online shopping**

You land from Google on a "Nike Air 200" page. The breadcrumb "Home > Men > Running Shoes" tells you the shop, the category and how to see similar shoes. Without it, the page is just an isolated island.

**⭐ Short answer for exam**

Building context = telling users where they are and how this place fits in the whole. Do it with the organization name and identity on every page, a clear hierarchy/breadcrumb path with the current location, and consistent navigation. It reduces the feeling of being lost and builds a mental model of the site.

## Q8. Improving flexibility — techniques and why adaptability matters

**📘 In simple words**

**Flexibility** means users can **move easily in many directions** — not only up and down the tree. A hierarchy alone is the foundation but is limiting.

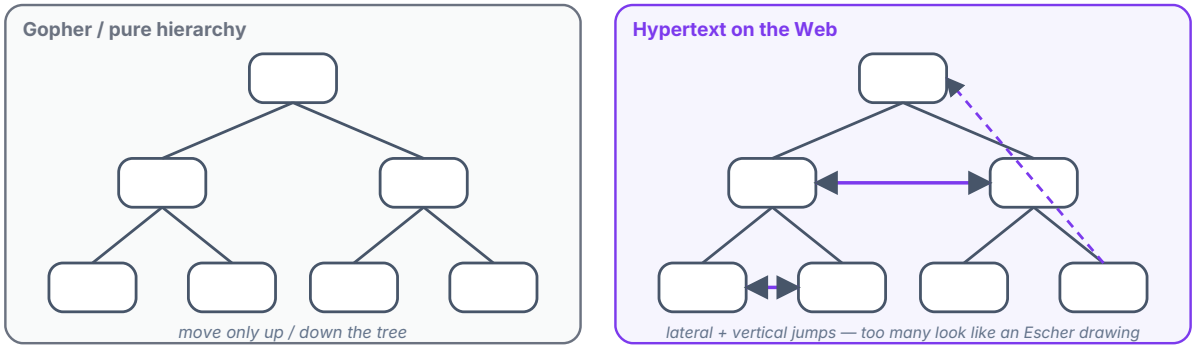



**Fig. 15** — Only up/down (Gopher) vs sideways links (hypertext)

### Techniques

| Technique | What it does | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Lateral links | Jump sideways to a related page | Programs → Registration |
| Vertical links | Go up a level quickly | Course page → Courses page |
| Home link | Back to start from anywhere | Logo on every page |
| Multiple paths | Same info reachable in many ways | Browse + search + index |

**Fig. 16** — Ways to add flexibility

- **Hypertext links** allow **lateral** moves between branches — e.g. from "Programs & Events" straight to "Registration" without going back to the top.

- **Vertical links** to move up a level (specific program → Programs page) or to the main page.
- **Global, local and ad hoc navigation** add flexibility on top of the hierarchy.
- **Multiple paths**: browse, search and index for the same content.

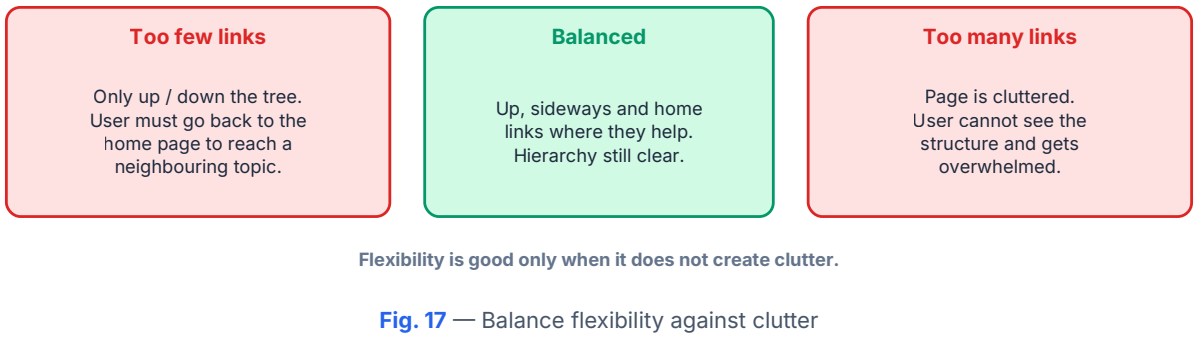



**Fig. 17** — Balance flexibility against clutter

> ⚠️ **Careful — The trick**
>
> Too few extra links = limiting. Too many = the hierarchy gets buried and users are overwhelmed. Navigation must **complement and reinforce** the hierarchy.

## Why adaptability is important in digital information management

- **Content keeps growing and changing** — new pages, products, departments.
- **Users differ** — some browse, some search, some know the exact name.
- A flexible, adaptable system can **add new content without a full redesign** (for example, a broad-and-shallow hierarchy and database-driven pages).
- It saves **money and time**, because big changes to the main page upset users and are costly.

> 🌍 **Real-life example — City roads**
>
> A city with only one-way main roads forces long detours. Cross streets (lateral links) let you reach the next area directly. But too many roads without signs cause chaos — that is the clutter problem.

> ⭐ **Short answer for exam**
>
> Flexibility is improved by adding **lateral and vertical links**, global/local/ad hoc navigation and multiple access paths on top of the hierarchy — carefully, to avoid clutter. Adaptability is important because content and users keep changing; flexible systems grow without redesign and suit different user needs.

PART C · QUESTIONS 9–12

# Navigation Systems & Usability

Types of navigation | Integrated vs remote | Elegant design | Usability & accessibility

## Q9. Types of navigation systems — with examples

**In simple words**

A **navigation system** is the set of signs, menus and links that help users move around a site and not get lost. There are **four main types**, plus supplemental (remote) tools.

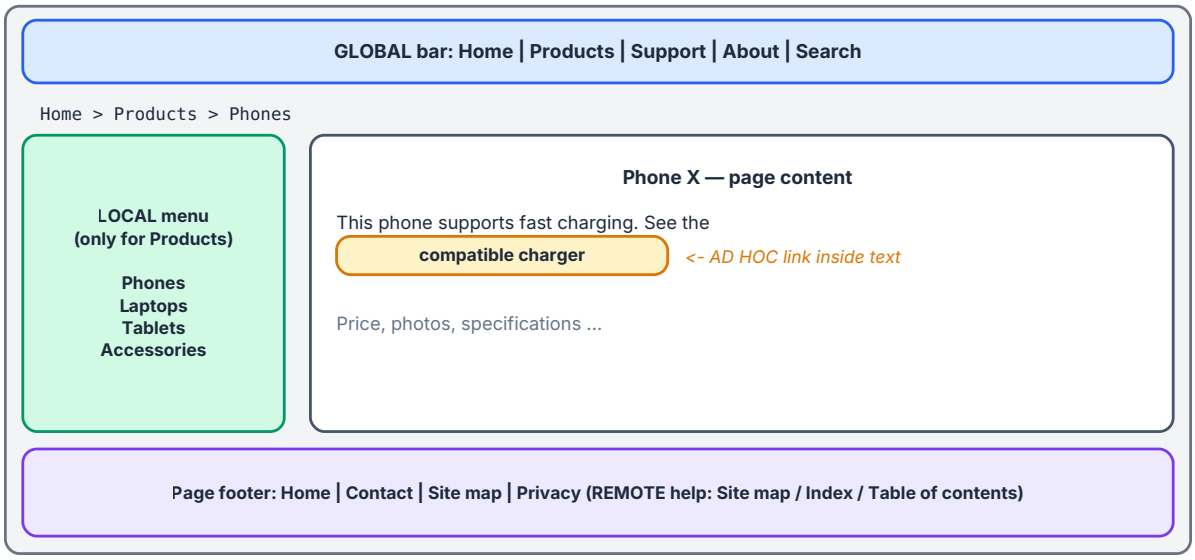



Fig. 18 — One page showing global, local and ad hoc navigation

| Type | Covers | Meaning and example |
|---|---|---|
| **1. Hierarchical** | The main structure | Moves from the main page down to the destination pages. Example: Home → Products → Phones → Phone X. Important but limited, so it needs the others. |
| **2. Global** | The whole site | Same bar on every page; adds sideways and vertical movement. Example: *Home* \| *Products* \| *Support* \| *About* bar at the top or bottom. |
| **3. Local** | One sub-site | Options for one area only. Example: inside Products, a menu with Phones \| Laptops \| Tablets. It **extends** the global bar, it does not replace it. |
| **4. Ad hoc** | Single content items | Links placed inside the text by an editor. Example: "See the compatible charger" inside a phone page. |

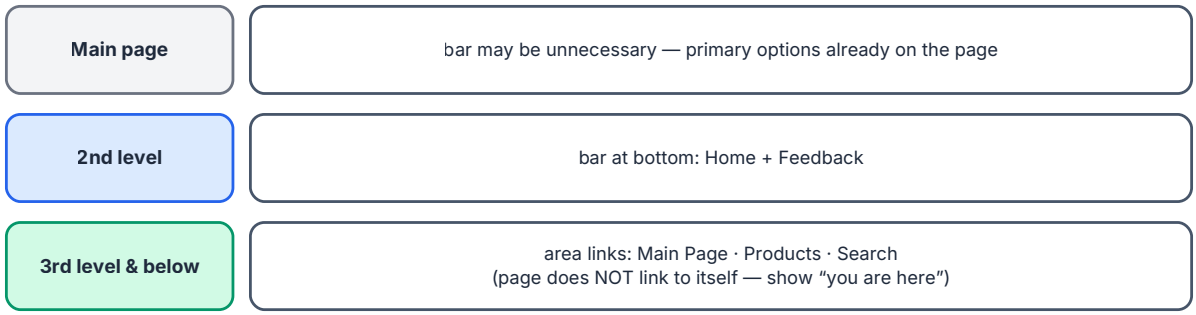



**Fig. 19** — How global and local navigation sit on the hierarchy

### Easy rules for each type

- **Global:** keep the same position on every page; main page link on the **left** (we read left to right); do not link a page to itself — show a "you are here" mark.
- **Local:** useful for complex sites; too many global + local options overwhelm users, so keep them few.
- **Ad hoc:** use for non-critical "points of interest". Users read fast and miss links buried in sentences; make the linked words meaningful (not a bare "1861"). Use in moderation.

### Supplemental (remote) tools

Table of contents, index, site map and guided tour (details in Q10).

🌍 **Real-life example — Hotel**

Global = the main notice board in the lobby (same for everyone). Local = the floor directory on each floor. Ad hoc = a sticky note on a door saying "Spa is next door". Hierarchical = the building's floor plan.

🧠 **Remember this — Order of design: H-G-L-A**

**H**ierarchy first → **G**lobal → **L**ocal → **A**d hoc.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

Navigation types: **hierarchical** (main tree), **global** (site-wide bar, vertical and lateral moves), **local** (options for a sub-site, extends global) and **ad hoc** (editorial links inside content). Example: a shop site with a global top bar, a local Products menu and a "see charger" link in a product page.

## Q10. Integrated vs remote navigation elements — and how they work together

📘 **In simple words**

**Integrated navigation elements** are built **into the content pages** (navigation bars, drop-down menus, frames).
**Remote navigation elements** are **outside** the basic hierarchy and give a bird's-eye view of the site (table of contents, index, site map, guided tour).

| | Integrated navigation | Remote navigation |
|---|---|---|
| Where | Inside the content pages | Separate, outside the main pages |
| Examples | Navigation bars, drop-down menus, frames | Table of contents, index, site map, guided tour |
| Purpose | Move around while reading | Give a bird's-eye view of the whole site |
| Always visible? | Yes — on the page | No — you open it when needed |
| Real-life | Road signs on the street | A city map or tourist guide |
| Role | Main navigation | Backup — never a replacement |

**Fig. 20** — Integrated vs remote — side by side

## Integrated elements

| Element | Notes |
|---|---|
| **Navigation bar** | **Text bar:** plain, fast, cheap, easy to change, works with low bandwidth. **Graphic bar:** nicer, but slower and costlier — use ALT text. Tip: graphic bar for global, text for local. Place at top and/or bottom. Words are clearer than icons; icons can help repeat users but may be understood differently in different cultures. |
| **Frames** | Split the window into scrollable panes; a bar stays visible while the content scrolls. **Problems:** waste screen space, break bookmarks/back/history, slower loading, complex design. |
| **Pull-down / pop-up menus** | Put many options in a small space. Good for an exact list (e.g. countries). **Caution:** hide options until clicked and invite cramming too many. |

## Remote elements

| Element | Notes |
|---|---|
| **Table of contents** | Shows the top few levels of the hierarchy with direct links. Not needed for tiny sites (2–3 levels). |
| **Index** | A–Z list of keywords (flat). Good for users who know the term. Index only content pages, not menu pages. **Term rotation** lists a phrase under both words, selectively. |
| **Site map** | A picture of the site's structure. Show only the important links, otherwise it becomes messy. |
| **Guided tour** | Step-by-step introduction for new users (good for subscription sites). Link it from the gateway page. |

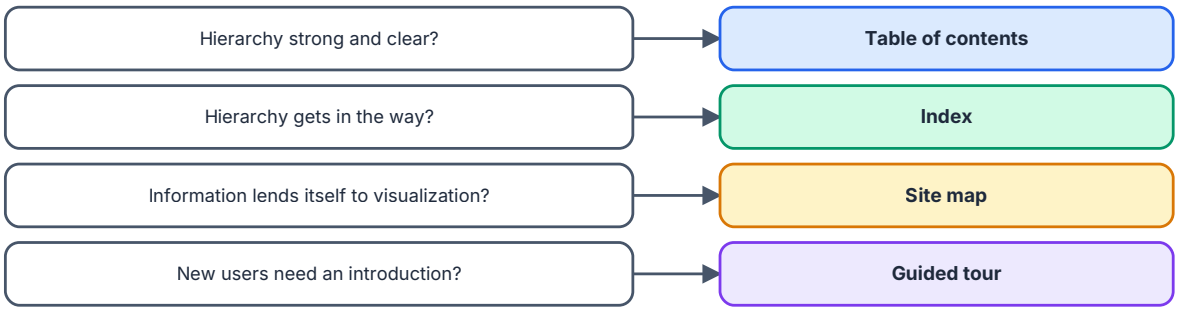



**Fig. 21** — Which remote element to choose

### How they enhance user experience together

- **Integrated** = everyday movement while working. **Remote** = help when you are lost or want the full picture.
- Different users get what they like: some use menus, some use the index or site map.
- Remote tools are like **help documents**: they support a good main system but can **never fix a poor one**.

🌍 **Real-life example — Road trip**

Road signs on the highway = integrated. A paper road map or GPS overview = remote. You need both, but you hope the signs are good enough that you rarely open the map.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

**Integrated** elements (navigation bars, frames, menus) are inside the content pages and used constantly; **remote** elements (table of contents, index, site map, guided tour) are external, give an overview and are opened when needed. Together they serve different users: integrated for everyday movement, remote as backup — but remote tools cannot replace a good main navigation.

## Q11. Principles of elegant navigation design — with good practices

📘 **In simple words**

**Elegant navigation** = simple, clear navigation that gives users **context**, **flexibility** and an easy way to **find information** — without flashy tricks.




**Fig. 22** — Six principles of elegant navigation

| Principle | Good practice example |
|---|---|
| **Show context** | Breadcrumb "Home > Men > Shoes"; current menu item highlighted; site name on every page. |
| **Add flexibility, not clutter** | A few well-chosen lateral and "home" links; not 50 links on every page. |
| **Be consistent** | Global bar always in the same place, same order; main page link leftmost. |
| **Keep it simple** | About 7 ± 2 options per menu; don't go deeper than 4–5 levels. |
| **Use clear labels** | Words users know ("Contact us"), text with icons; ALT text for graphics. |
| **Don't link to yourself** | The current page is shown as "you are here", not as a clickable link. |
| **Respect the browser** | Keep standard link colours; avoid frames that break back/bookmarks. |
| **Think about goals, audience, content** | No single combination fits every site; choose elements to match. |
| **Function over fashion** | Prefer fast text/CSS menus over heavy graphics, flashy pop-ups or dynamic maps. |
| **Test with users** | Watch real users; fix where they get lost. Build testing into the process. |

### Recommended design order

**Hierarchy → Global → Local → Ad hoc** (each level shapes the next), and only **then** remote elements such as a table of contents or site map. Large sites can use two remote elements (e.g. table of contents + index) but should watch confusion and maintenance cost.

🌍 **Real-life example — Good example**

A good e-commerce site: global top bar (Home, Categories, Cart, Account), breadcrumb on each page, a local filter menu for each category, and a footer with Site map and Help.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

Principles: show **context**, add **flexibility** without clutter, be **consistent**, keep it **simple**, use **clear labels**, respect the **browser**, design for goals/audience/content, favour function over flash and **test with users**. Design in the order hierarchy → global → local → ad hoc → remote.

## Q12. Information organization, usability and accessibility

📘 **In simple words**

**Usability** = how easy a site is to use. **Accessibility** = whether **everyone**, including people with disabilities (low vision, hearing loss, motor difficulty), can use it. Information organization is the **backbone** of both.

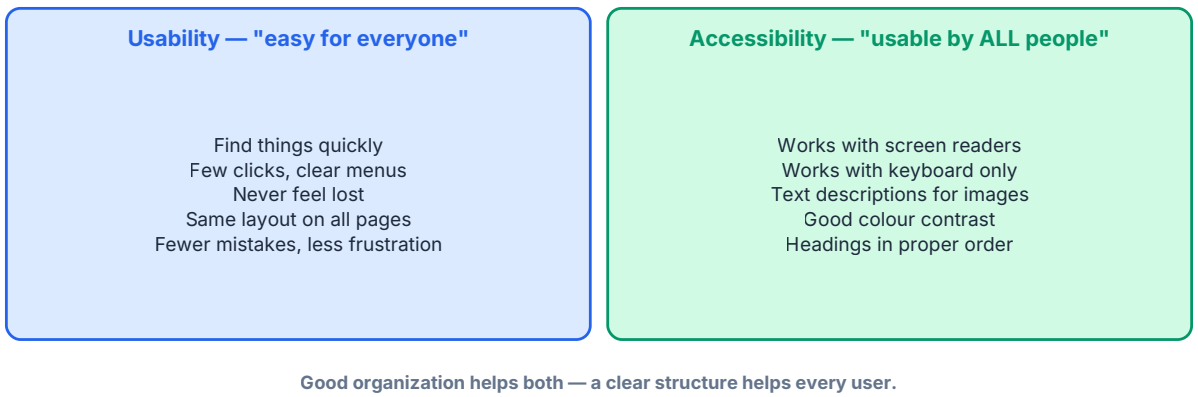



**Fig. 23** — Usability and accessibility

## How organization improves usability

- **Fast finding:** clear categories and labels, so users reach content in few clicks.
- **Learnability:** a consistent structure is learned once and works on every page.
- **Fewer errors and less frustration:** context cues (breadcrumbs, "you are here") stop users from feeling lost.
- **Several routes:** browsing, searching, index and site map suit different habits.
- **Easy to grow:** a broad, shallow hierarchy takes new content without confusion.

## How organization supports accessibility

| Practice | Why it helps |
|---|---|
| **Simple, logical hierarchy with headings in order** | Screen-reader users hear the structure and can jump from heading to heading. |
| **Text labels with ALT text for images and icons** | Blind users hear what the picture or icon means (also helps text-only browsers and low bandwidth). |
| **Navigation that works with keyboard only** | Users who cannot use a mouse can still move through menus. |
| **Consistent places for menus** | Easier for users with memory or attention difficulties. |
| **Good colour contrast and normal link colours** | Easier for users with low vision or colour blindness. |
| **Fewer, clearer choices** | Less overload for everyone, especially for people with cognitive difficulties. |
| **Site map / index as another route** | An alternative to complex menus or pop-ups. |

## Web and intranet

On a **website** the users are the public, so accessibility is also a legal and reputation matter. On an **intranet** employees use the system daily, so good organization saves working time and supports staff with different abilities.

**⚠️ Careful — Beyond the textbook**

Accessibility details (screen readers, keyboard use, contrast, ALT text) are standard general web practice added for this question; the textbook mainly covers usability points such as context, flexibility, text labels with ALT text and avoiding frames/pop-ups that hide options.

🌍 **Real-life example — Staircase and ramp**

A building with a clear floor plan is easy for all visitors (usability). Adding a ramp and lift lets wheelchair users in too (accessibility). A well-organized site is the floor plan; ALT text and keyboard support are the ramp.

⭐ **Short answer for exam**

Good information organization makes a site easy to use (clear categories and labels, consistent structure, context, multiple paths) and accessible (logical hierarchy and headings, text labels and ALT text, keyboard-friendly navigation, good contrast). Both improve satisfaction on websites and productivity on intranets.

# One-page revision sheet

| Q | Topic | Remember |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Organizing info | Group + label so users can find and understand. Saves time, better results, less confusion. |
| 2 | Challenges | **A-H-P-P**: Ambiguity, Heterogeneity, Perspectives, Politics. Fix: scope notes, small homogeneous parts, user view, compromise. |
| 3 | Websites / intranets | System = **schemes + structures**. Exact: A-C-G. Ambiguous: T-T-A-M. Structures: hierarchy, database, hypertext. 7 ± 2 and 4–5 levels. |
| 4 | Cohesive system | Exact + ambiguous together; all three structures; multiple paths; small domains; pure schemes. |
| 5 | WWW, metadata | Metadata = data about data. Controlled vocabulary + scope notes. Categories narrow results. |
| 6 | Browser features | URL, back/forward, history, bookmark, link colours, prospective view. Don't break them. |
| 7 | Context | "You are here": org name on every page, hierarchy path, highlight current location. |
| 8 | Flexibility | Lateral + vertical links, global/local/ad hoc. Balance vs clutter. Adaptability = growth without redesign. |
| 9 | Navigation types | **H-G-L-A**: hierarchical, global, local, ad hoc. |
| 10 | Integrated vs remote | Integrated: bars, frames, menus. Remote: **T-I-S-G** (TOC, index, site map, guided tour). Remote never replaces a good main system. |
| 11 | Elegant design | Context, flexibility, consistency, simplicity, clear labels, test with users; hierarchy → global → local → ad hoc → remote. |
| 12 | Usability & accessibility | Clear structure helps everyone; ALT text, keyboard, headings, contrast help all abilities. |

# Revision checklist

- ☐ Define organizing information and give 3 reasons it matters (Q1)
- ☐ Four challenges with an example each (Q2)
- ☐ Scheme vs structure; exact vs ambiguous; hybrid problem (Q3)
- ☐ Hierarchy rules: breadth/depth, 7 ± 2 (Q3)
- ☐ Cohesive system characteristics (Q4)
- ☐ Metadata and controlled vocabulary (Q5)
- ☐ Browser features and how designers break them (Q6)
- ☐ Context rules and example (Q7)
- ☐ Flexibility techniques and the clutter trade-off (Q8)
- ☐ Global / local / ad hoc with examples (Q9)
- ☐ Integrated vs remote comparison table (Q10)
- ☐ Elegant navigation principles and design order (Q11)
- ☐ Usability vs accessibility with examples (Q12)